During the visit to Sri Lanka, I met with the Sri Lankan Army Chief, Gen Shavendra Silva, who is currently their CDS. I also had the occasion to call on the President, Prime Minister and Defence Minister. It was evident from this that they attached a lot of importance to their relations with India and were very grateful for all the 'no strings attached' assistance we were extending, unlike China, which had drawn them into a debt trap. During the visit, a Driving Simulator and an Infantry Weapons Training Simulator were presented to the Sri Lankan Army, both of which had been developed in-house by our Simulator Development Division. Gen Silva and I even went to witness the joint Sri Lanka–India exercise, 'Mitra Shakti', at the Combat Training School, Ampara. I was also taken to Trincomalee for old times' sake, where I saw that my 4th Mile Post was now, of all things, a Tata showroom. I also laid a wreath at the IPKF Memorial constructed in 2008 by Sri Lanka at Sri Jayewardenepura Kotte on the outskirts of Colombo. The names of the 1200 soldiers who died are inscribed on black marble under the words, 'Valiant Were Their Deeds, Undying Be Their Memories'.

My visit to Bangladesh coincided with the Swarnim Vijay Varsh, the Golden Jubilee of the Bangladesh War of Liberation of 1971. It was also the birth centenary year of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, who had played a pivotal role in their independence movement, going on to become their first Prime Minister, before being tragically assassinated in 1975, and the nationalistic fervour was visible everywhere. Along with Gen Aziz Ahmed, we also went to Mirpur to see the finale of 'Ex Shantir Ogrosena', a multinational exercise set up for carrying out a peacekeeping role under the UN, in which troops from Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Bhutan and India participated, besides observers from other South East Asian Countries. In her

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